INTERVIEW

"Our focus is on Mathura and Kashi only"

Vishva Hindu Parishad president Alok Kumar spoke to Anilesh S. Mahajan on the row surrounding Aurangzeb's tomb and the Hindu right's temple revival movements. Excerpts:



ANI

Q. How do you see the recent controversy around Aurangzeb and subsequent violence in Nagpur?
Our view is very clear. There should not be any glorification of Aurangzeb.... He imprisoned his own father; brutally killed his own brothers; executed Sufi saint Sarmad Kashani, Sikh Guru Tegh Bahadur; the entire family of Guru Gobind Singh was killed on his instructions; led large-scale conversions; desecrated temples. He can't be our hero.

Q. There has been a call for razing his tomb...
The VHP and other affiliates are working to build monuments that commemorate the heroes who stood against Aurangzeb. It is their valour and courage that must be taught to future generations.

Q. There is a similar confrontation at Sambhal in UP.
There is no confrontation with the VHP there. There were law and order issues, which the local government dealt with.

Q. There have been concerns that a particular community and its historical structures are being targeted. What is your stand?
As the VHP, we are very clear. We are taking up the issue of only Krishna Janmabhoomi temple in Mathura and the revival of 'Gyanvapi Temple' in Kashi. There is a full stop. We are taking legal recourse and are determined to recover these temples through constitutional ways. Gyanvapi, too, was desecrated by Aurangzeb.

Q. RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat, in June 2022, had said that there is no need to look for a Shivling in every mosque. But we are still seeing lots of disputes being raked up.
Absolutely. What the RSS chief says is true. We should look for Shivlings only where they are; not in every mosque. Right now, our focus is on Mathura and Kashi, and nowhere else. ■

"There should be no glorification of Aurangzeb. We are working to build monuments to commemorate heroes who stood against him"

dargah is located in Ahmednagar," he says.

Chhatrapati Shivaji, meanwhile, has become a figure of unique historical and contemporary significance, with all shades of public opinion appropriating the Maratha stalwart for political ends. While the Hindutva side sees him as a Hindu king taking on the might of the Muslim rulers, leftist ideologues like Govind Pansare project him as a people's king who took on the established order of the day across caste and religious lines to establish a welfare state.

In fact, Marathi historian Indrajeet Sawant sees Aurangzeb's tomb as a symbol of Maratha valour. Sanjay Sonawani, writer and activist, begs to differ, though. "Aurangzeb died at age 89 and was buried at Khultabad as per the wish expressed in his will," he says. "He would have been interred here even if he died elsewhere. Claims that his grave being located in Maharashtra symbolises Maratha valour do not hold."

Political analyst Abhay Deshpande is convinced that the Aurangzeb issue has been raised with an eye on the local body polls scheduled later this year. Besides catching the opposition Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray) in a bind on the issue of Hindutva—the SS(UBT) has developed an auxiliary base among Muslims—the controversy also laid bare the oneupmanship within the ruling alliance. "The BJP and Shiv Sena are trying to show that their version of Hindutva is more strident," he says. Both parties have taken an aggressive position on the issue, but their ally, the Nationalist Congress Party